

On Søren Kierkegaard's Work as a Religious Author

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It could not have been otherwise than that the death of a man who had awakened in so many serious thoughts, strong passions—those of love and of hatred—must have set these thoughts, these passions, into living motion. At such a moment it is natural to strive to survey what is now concluded, to seek in the clear image of what he willed and accomplished a sure hold for one's thoughts and for one's judgment. To give such an image—one that the author of these lines has been unable to find in what has been written about Kierkegaard since his death—this presentation is meant to contribute; it keeps throughout to his own words, and will attempt to show, on the one hand, the inner connection and unity in the whole series of his writings, and, on the other, how closely his last appearance is bound up with his earlier activity, how definitely it was foreshadowed therein, and with what necessary consistency it had, under the given circumstances, to proceed from it.

The literary activity that is here to be discussed begins in February 1843 with *Either/Or*. Before this work Kierkegaard had indeed published two writings: *From the Papers of One Still Living, Published Against His Will by S.K.* (1838), and the master's dissertation *On the Concept of Irony, with Continual Reference to Socrates* (1841). But although the first of these writings—in its polemic against the merging of the single individual into the impersonal mass, in its conception of the relation of the preceding generation to the present, in its intimation of the religious goal (p. 30), and finally in much of its form (especially the preface)—recalls his later works, it nevertheless stands, by its accidental occasion and limited subject, isolated, outside the coherent series; and although the second and incomparably more significant writing, the treatise on irony, develops a concept of high importance for K.'s conception of the stages of existence, and although

(in its second part, especially pp. 287–304) it gives the categorical determination of what in the first part of *Either/Or* appears in personal existence and in the second part finds its judgment, it is nevertheless essentially a learned work, in which the philological and historical apparatus occupies the preponderant place, and what gives it a more general significance is again taken up in its place in the later writings, notably in “Concluding Unscientific Postscript.”

The properly coherent literary activity thus begins with *Either/Or*, reaches its decisive point in “Concluding Unscientific Postscript” (February 1846), its provisional conclusion in “Two Discourses at the Communion on Fridays” (late summer 1851; cf. the preface to these), and its final conclusion only at the author’s death. “Concluding Postscript”—which, if any single one of K.’s writings is to be singled out, must be designated his chief work—forms the midpoint in the series of his writings and divides them into two groups, of which the first strives toward the Christian, the second presents the Christian thus attained.

The Christian is thus the goal, the task, and is so from the very first. “The authorship, regarded as a totality, is religious from first to last.” — “The problem, the problem of the whole authorship, is: becoming a Christian.” — “To this authorship there corresponds, as its source, one who *qua* author has willed only one thing.” — More precisely, this that he has willed is determined thus: “Without authority, to call attention to the religious, the Christian.” (On My Work as an Author, pp. 7, 9, 14). But those who were to be made aware were those who in “Christendom” live in “the sensory illusion of calling themselves Christians, perhaps imagining themselves to be such, without being so.” The task was then not in the first instance to give, but first, as it were, to take away, to remove what favored the illusion, and thus, by the maieutic, by that “art of the midwife,” as Socrates called it, to help the single individual himself “to give birth to the truth.” But the manner in which the illusion was to be combated was conditioned by its ground. This lay partly in the whole tendency of the age: that, reflective and dispassionate, it had let the understanding level everything, and let “the single individual” disappear into “the phantom of abstraction, the public”; that it, “essentially sensible, perhaps on the average more knowing than any generation before it,” had “forgotten what it means to exist and what inwardness is”; that it, impersonally and disinterestedly losing itself in the objective, had forgotten appropriation, forgotten the task of existing in one’s knowledge; — partly it lay in the confusing intermixture of the different views of life, grounded in the fact that the secularization of Christianity and the forgetting of the passion of personality had led to the forgetting of Christianity’s ideal requirement. To

dispel the illusion, these views of life had first to be brought forward in their pronounced distinctiveness, and brought forward not as an object of knowledge—for in that way the very tendency of the age away from existence and from existence's decision would be favored—but in a form that asserts the significance of existence, that compels the reader to acquire the understanding personally, by himself. He is “made aware”; the rest is left to himself; the indirect communication conceals the communicator from him, makes him as it were unrecognizable; he must now help himself in the appropriation, and in the appropriation of that which, by being presented in existence, is only indirectly communicated, he is personally to experience where the stumbling-block of the lower view of life lies, where it strikes against passion, where existence loses its foundation, and where despair leads either out into perdition or up to the higher, to “being saved infinitely in the essentiality of religiousness” (cf. *A Literary Review*. 1846. pp. 108 ff.). But since the earlier stages of life were to be presented not by way of doctrine, as an object of knowledge, but in existing individualities, the first series of writings had to be pseudonymous. The pseudonymity had “its essential ground in the production itself, which, for the sake of the lines, for the sake of the psychologically varied differences of individuality, poetically required that recklessness in good and evil, in contrition and exuberance, in despair and arrogance, in suffering and jubilation, and so on, that is ideally bounded only by psychological consistency, which no factually real person, within reality's ethical limitation, dares to allow himself, or could wish to allow himself” (Appendix to the Concluding Postscript). The pseudonyms are thus poetically created authors, like dramatic characters, who live in their views and express these in their whole ideal consistency.

In the first of the pseudonymous writings, *Either/Or, a Fragment of Life*, edited by Victor Eremita (1843), the two stages of life that lie prior to the religious—the aesthetic and the ethical—are presented in existing personalities. “The aesthetic in a person is that by which he immediately is what he is; whoever lives in and by and of and for this lives aesthetically”; his watchword is enjoyment, his goal perdition. The first part presents such an aesthetic individuality, tossed about among possibilities that his imagination conjures up and his dialectic again annihilates, split apart in the passion of isolated moments, without the coherence of existence, without actuality, captive to despair. The second part presents a single individuality who, in despair's relinquishment of the immediacy of the aesthetic, has made the movement of infinity, whereby the ethical first comes into view; who in despair has found himself again in his eternal validity, has chosen himself, who in this choice has become manifest in the universal, and through

this has gained the possibility of giving his life continuity. The work's conclusion, an upbuilding discourse, leads to the boundary of the religious, and, by bringing in the upbuilding, accentuates the significance of subjectivity, of appropriation, in the relation to truth.

After *Either/Or* there followed three smaller pseudonymous writings: *Fear and Trembling*, *Repetition* (1843) and *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), which successively bring forward the religious determinations, whereas *Either/Or* had given the aesthetic and ethical ones. They present in existence the collision between the religious and the ethical, the ordeal, the struggle in which the God-relationship is victorious, and finally the decisive determination of the religious: sin, which posits the individual as heterogeneous with the ethical, so that he cannot in despair assert himself by himself, win himself out of despair, but only by a higher, by the God-relationship, in self-annihilation. Simultaneously with the last of these writings there appeared a little book, full of sparkling wit and biting satire: "Prefaces, Light Reading for Certain Classes as the Occasion May Require," which in its last section, jestingly but in earnest, points to religious equality, to the requirement that the highest for a human being must be that which is accessible to all, in contrast to the accidental difference of talent. ("This thought of humanity and of human equality: Christianly, every human being (the single individual), unconditionally every human being, is equally near to God." (Preface to Two Discourses at the Communion)).

The religious had now been reached in its essential determination, in the determination of sin. This was not developed by way of doctrine—"for sin, like faith, the paradox, and the like, has no place in the System"—but brought forward in its psychological existence in the individual as anxiety. Now it was certain that the Christian was not confused with anything lower, and "Philosophical Fragments" (1844) now set it forth in the form of a hypothesis, experimentally. The form here conditioned pseudonymity, the subject-matter naming; hence K.'s name appears on this writing as editor. The problem in this writing is: "Can there be given a historical point of departure for an eternal consciousness; how can such a one be of more than historical interest; can one build an eternal happiness upon a historical knowledge?" The hypothesis in it is: "if one is to go further than the Socratic," that is, than the view of life borne by the thought of immanence, in which time, finitude, becomes the vanishing element eternally taken up into the infinite; in which the settledness of eternity makes existence, however earnestly it is taken, into a jest; in which the teacher becomes merely the occasion for the learner, because the latter eternally has the truth; in which the very consciousness of guilt does not reach beyond death, because the finite personality does not reach beyond it. "If, then,

one is to go further,” other decisive determinations must be posited, and now, through a construction that parodies speculation, the orthodox-Christian determinations come forth in their whole simplicity. The hypothesis now becomes: “a new organ: faith; a new presupposition: the consciousness of sin; a new decision: the moment; a new teacher: God in time.”

Simultaneously with these pseudonymous writings, K. had, under his own name, published six small collections of upbuilding discourses, with constant aim at the category of religion: “the single individual,”¹ which drew nearer and nearer to the Christian-religious, without, however, willing to reach it, since they concluded in the humorous.

At the conclusion of Philosophical Fragments another writing had been intimated, in which “the problem was to be clothed in historical costume.” But before this there appeared “Stages on Life’s Way” (1845), in which the three stages of existence—the aesthetic, the ethical, and the religious—were more definitely delineated, and the fundamental determination of the religious life, suffering, was sharply accentuated. The year after there appeared “Concluding Unscientific Postscript to the Philosophical Fragments,” like the “Fragments” with K.’s name as editor. Here the problem of the subject’s relation to Christianity, or: becoming a Christian, is decisively posed; subjectivity as the truth for the existing person is asserted against the objectivity-theories; the significance of existence is asserted against speculation’s looking-away from existence; indirectly the point is indicated where the earlier views of life must run aground; the spheres of existence are more definitely distinguished from one another; irony is determined as the *confinium* between the aesthetic and the ethical, humor as the *confinium* between the ethical and the religious; the religious sphere is divided into two: the religiousness that rests in immanence, and the Christian, whose fundamental determination—“in which all the other Christian determinations lie, and from which they let themselves be consistently derived”—is this: “that in time the question of the individual’s eternal happiness is decided, and decided by the relation to Christianity as something historical,” in which fundamental determination the possibility of offense lies.

With this writing the goal, the Christian, had been decisively reached; it had been brought forward in its absolute difference from the earlier stages, not as an object of knowledge, but as the object of faith: the paradox, the despair of knowledge, the

¹“It is Christian heroism — to venture wholly to become oneself, a single human being, this definite single human being, alone before God, alone in this enormous exertion and this enormous responsibility” (The Sickness unto Death, Preface). — It was to this “single individual, whom with joy and gratitude I call my reader,” that the prefaces to all the upbuilding discourses addressed themselves. On the relation of the single individual to “the congregation,” K. has expressed himself more fully in Practice in Christianity, pp. 235 f. (new edition); cf. On My Work as an Author, p. 12, note; A Literary Review, pp. 107 f.

stumbling-block of offense. The religious had been the goal; it had “wholly and entirely been set into reflection, but in such a way that it was wholly and entirely taken out of reflection back into simplicity”; the road traversed had been “to attain, to come to simplicity”; the task “not to reflect oneself into Christianity, but to reflect oneself out of something else and become, more and more simply, a Christian.”

After the series of pseudonymous writings there followed the series of upbuilding ones: first “Upbuilding Discourses in Various Spirits” (1847), in which, as the title indicates, the upbuilding from the earlier stages was taken up, so that only the last third gave the distinctively Christian; thereafter *Works of Love*, *Christian Deliberations in the Form of Discourses* (1847) and *Christian Discourses* (1848), to which in the immediately following years several smaller collections attached themselves, ever more definitely striving toward what is the midpoint of Christianity, so that, as K. then expressed it, the whole literary activity might find “its decisive resting-point at the foot of the altar, where the author, himself best conscious of his own imperfection and guilt, by no means calls himself a witness to the truth, but only a peculiar kind of poet and thinker who, ‘without authority,’ has had nothing new to bring, but has ‘wished to read through the original text of the individual, humane conditions of existence—the old, familiar text handed down from the fathers—once again, if possible in a more inward way.” (Preface to *Two Discourses at the Communion on Fridays*, 1851.)

The task of the upbuilding writings was “with God’s help to use everything in order to make clear what Christianity’s requirement in truth is,” not to conduct an apology for Christianity, but “to present it, what truth is, as something so infinitely high that the apology falls in another place, becomes, for us, that we dare to call ourselves Christians, or transforms itself into a penitent confession, that we thank God when we merely dare to regard ourselves as Christians.” But alongside the severity of the infinite requirement, the infinity of grace was not forgotten; only the requirement had to “be heard and asserted first, heard and asserted in its whole infinity,” before “grace” could be applied. “What I have willed is to contribute, by means of admissions, to bringing if possible somewhat more truth into these (in the direction of being an ethical and ethical-religious character, of renouncing worldly shrewdness, of being willing to suffer for the truth, and the like) imperfect existences such as we lead them, which is nevertheless always something, and in any case the first condition for coming to exist more capably. What I have willed to prevent is that one should then not, restricting oneself to and contenting oneself with the easier and lower, thereupon go further, abolish the higher, — go further, set the lower in the higher’s place, — go further, make the higher into the fantast and

ridiculous exaggeration, the lower into wisdom and true earnestness; that one should not then, in 'Christendom,' existentially take Luther and the significance of Luther's life in vain: this I have willed to contribute, if possible, to preventing" (On My Work as an Author, p. 18).

Christianity's requirement in its "severity" was asserted in two writings that appeared pseudonymously, with the author's name as editor. In the first, *The Sickness unto Death, a Christian Psychological Exposition for Upbuilding and Awakening* (1849), the sickness unto death—that is, despair—is conceived as sin, and this as the opposite of faith, whose object is the paradox, the absurd for thought; the possibility of offense is held fast as the dialectical moment in all that is Christian. In the second writing, the one that marks the decisive turning-point in K.'s relation to the existing official Church, *Practice in Christianity* (published 1850, written 1848), "the requirement of being a Christian was forced up to a highest of ideality" in the direction of a relation of contemporaneity to the prototype, of making the prototype's life present in our own, of suffering, of self-annihilation, of faith in conflict with the understanding under the inseparable possibility of offense. This book was a question posed to the ecclesiastically established order. In the conception of suffering as the inseparable mark of religiousness, in the conception of Christianity as heterogeneity with the world, as a requirement of imitation of the prototype, of "transformation of existence in likeness to God," there was pronounced a judgment upon a "Christendom" that has made itself comfortable in the world, found rest in worldliness; upon a clergy that, protected by the State, in the enjoyment of well-being proclaims the religion of suffering. What was later expressed in "The Moment" was here not merely intimated but, in all essentials, expressly stated (cf. especially pp. 41, 75, 123, 136, 209, 228, 241, 243 f., 268 in the new edition). But, disinclined as K. was to work toward a change in externals, he made, in the preface he added to the book, yet one more attempt to give the established order a means of defense. "My thought was: if this established order is to be defensible, this is the only way: by poetically (therefore by a pseudonym) lodging the judgment upon it, by then drawing in a second power upon 'grace,' so that it became Christianity, not merely by 'grace' to find forgiveness for the past, but by grace a kind of indulgence from the actual imitation of Christ and the actual exertion involved in being a Christian. In this way truth nevertheless enters into the established order; it defends itself by judging itself, it concedes the Christian requirement, makes confession concerning itself as to its distance, and without being able to be called a striving in the direction of coming nearer to the requirement, but takes refuge in grace 'also with respect to the use one makes of grace.'" ("Fædrelandet"

for 16 May 1855; cf. the Editor's Preface to *Practice in Christianity*, and: *On My Work as an Author*, pp. 17, 19, note.)

The question was now posed to the official Church, in the first instance to its head, the late Bishop Mynster; in the judgment upon it the head of the Church would pronounce his own and the Church's own judgment. "If there were strength in him, he would have to do one of two things: either decidedly declare himself for the book, dare to go along with it, let it be the defense that wards off what the book poetically contains, the charge against the whole official Christianity that it is an optical illusion, 'not worth a rotten herring,' or else as decidedly as possible throw himself against it, brand it as a blasphemous and sacrilegious attempt, and declare the official Christianity to be the true Christianity." Neither was done: "impotent, he chose to do nothing, except at most to condemn it in the drawing-room; but not even in private conversation with me, although I asked him to, after it had been brought before him, with his consent, what he was judging in the drawing-room." ("Fædrel." in the place cited.)

So the matter stood while Mynster lived. Only the shyness about hastening a decision in externals—a shyness grounded as much in K.'s conception of the essence of the ethical and the religious as in his conception of the development through which the age had to be healed (cf. the remarkable conclusion of "A Literary Review." 1846. pp. 107 ff.)—his piety toward Mynster, preserved from the impressions of childhood, and probably also the hope, against all probability, of seeing the thought "so infinitely dear to him" become reality, that Mynster might still say: "this is in truth Christianity, thus do I myself understand Christianity in quiet inwardness," so that the book would become a transfiguration of Bishop Mynster's proclamation of Christianity—could still hold him back from the decisive step. Then Mynster died, and at his grave his successor proclaimed him a witness to the truth, one of the genuine witnesses to the truth. With this judgment the answer was given to the question that had been posed by "Practice in Christianity." The official Church had now declared that its proclamation of Christianity, "which toned down and kept silent the decisive Christian," was the true one; that Christianity in its ideal requirement, the Christianity of the New Testament, was exaggeration, overwroughtness. Now the protest had to be made against this Church; now first the necessity of the opposition drove him to carry the matter to the utmost (cf. "This Must Be Said." p. 10). Yet it did not happen rashly; only almost a year after Mynster's death and his successor's canonizing of him was the protest made public (in "Fædrel." for 18 December 1854). What has happened since that time is still in fresh memory. In the articles in "Fædrelandet" and in "The Moment" the fight was waged for Christianity

against Christendom and its silent representative, the clergy. It was now declared: "Whoever you are, whatever your life may otherwise be, my friend; — by (if otherwise you take part in it) refraining from taking part in the public worship of God as it now is (with the claim of being the Christianity of the New Testament), you have always one guilt the less, and a great one; you do not take part in making a fool of God by calling that the Christianity of the New Testament which is not the Christianity of the New Testament." ("This Must Be Said; So Let It Be Said." p. 3). The demand was made upon the State "to take away that sensory illusion" of a Church that in worldliness had been fused together with the worldly, of a clergy "whose existence, Christianly, is an untruth," "whose Christian earnestness finds its expression in this, that 'witnesses to the truth' make—what satirical self-contradiction!—career and fortune in the world by depicting on Sundays how the truth must suffer in this world!"; whose whole position compels it to conceal from the congregation what Christianity is, and thus, so far as it depends on it, to make it impossible. All the contradictions that lie in the clergy's position, all the deception it has brought into "Christendom," were laid bare with biting satire: "The Almighty knows best how the blows are to be struck so that it is felt, that laughter, served in fear and trembling, must be the scourge—therefore I am used." And against the wretched half-measure that has retained merely the name of Christianity, against the delusion "that being a Christian is something everyone is as a matter of course, something one comes by more easily than the most insignificant skill," the ideal was set up, earnestly and in judgment. It is now two months since the last number of "The Moment" appeared; a few days after, illness confined the author to the sickbed from which he did not rise again. His activity is now concluded, and when we look back over it, we shall find his words true, that he "as an author has willed only one thing." To call attention to the Christian was the task of his life; it was the task in the first series of his writings, which worked against the confusion of the Christian with what is not Christian, against the confounding of a knowledge about Christianity with a transformation of existence by Christianity; it was the task in his upbuilding writings, which, with deep knowledge of the hidden passions of the human heart, knew how to track down every self-deception, to block every way out by which one might evade becoming the Christian; it was the task in his struggle against the Church that kept silent the Christian, "made Christianity into poetry, into something to which one relates oneself only through the imagination," abolished the imitation of Christ in suffering, in dying away from the world—the Church that "cast the prototype away and let what one is oneself, mediocrity, pass for the ideal." And what he, in his life so early ended, fought

for—with a strength of will that did not let itself be bent by the body's weakness, and with a faith that did not despair—has not been without fruit. His earlier writings have worked in quiet in an ever-larger circle; his "Moments" have, in their thousands, opened the eye and awakened serious thoughts that will not be forgotten now that he is dead, but find new nourishment in the writings he has left behind, in the life he has awakened in so many souls.

—r.